

Sarah Akhavan

UX Researcher and Accessibility Advocate with 7+ years of experience

sarahakhavan.info
sarah.9473@gmail.com
647-468-8900

EXPERIENCE

Senior UX Researcher | Practices in Enabling Technologies (PiET) Lab, York University

JUL 2020 - PRESENT, Toronto

- Led teams of junior researchers to conduct research, prototype, design, and develop accessible technologies.
- Conducted qualitative and quantitative research, identifying key insights to improve user experience for diverse user groups, including those with disabilities.
- Developed and implemented usability testing frameworks, conducted data analysis, and led design evaluations across multiple projects.

Notable Projects:

AcTinSite Project (PRESENT)

- Directing a group of junior researchers on designing an accessible interactive resource for accommodation in work-integrated learning.
- Conducted in-depth qualitative research, identifying key patterns and insights from human participants, particularly those in need of accommodations.

Inclusive Open-Source Assistive Technologies

- Developed an empirically derived **group persona** technique for increasing inclusion in the design of Open-Source Assistive Technologies,
- Applied the concept to a case study of a writing system for people with deaf-blindness and motor impairments.

SmART Toolbox Study

- Designed a **usability evaluation framework** for the SmART Toolbox.
- Conducted **thematic analysis** over 151 entries.
- Designed and directed **Think Aloud sessions** as part of the test stage.

UX Researcher | Practices in Enabling Technologies (PiET) Lab, York University

SEP 2018 - JUL 2020

Treasure Box Braille

- Collaborated on research projects aimed at creating accessible learning and DIY tools for visually impaired children.
- Contributed to the design of 3D assembly guidelines for DIY circuits and developed accessible tutorials for assembling the Treasure Box Braille.

EDUCATION

MSc HCI | York University

SEP 2018 - JUL 2022

BSc Software Engineering

| Amirkabir University of Technology

SEP 2013 - AUG 2018

SKILLS

UX Research & Design:

Qualitative Research • Quantitative Research • Contextual Inquiry • Affinity Mapping • Experience Mapping • Wireframing • Prototyping • Usability Testing • Cognitive Walkthrough • Tree Testing • Heuristic Evaluation • Designing for Accessibility • WCAG

Design Tools:

Figma • Sketch • InVision • Zeplin • Adobe XD • Illustrator • Adee • Procreate • Treejack

Data Mining & Analysis:

EXCEL • WEKA • Rapidminer • Scikit-Learn • Pandas • Matplotlib • Numpy

Web Development:

HTML • CSS • JS • Node.js • React Redux • RESTful API

Director of UX Design and Research Courses | York University

MAY 2020 - PRESENT, Toronto

- Educated over 1100 students on **UX Research Methods, Analysis of User Data, understanding of human cognition, emotion, and behavior, Modeling and Visualizing derived conclusions, and prototyping and usability evaluation.**
- Held over 13 workshops, covering topics like **UX research methods, prototyping, accessibility in design, data analysis and behavioral analysis, information mapping and data visualization, communication with stakeholders.**
- Championed the implementation of accessible web interfaces, teaching students how to integrate web technologies in alignment with accessibility best practices.
- Facilitated real-world project integration with my courses in partnership with YorkU Project Commons.

Graduate Entrance Scholarship / Lassonde School of Engineering • Fall 2018

2nd Place / Local ACM Contest • 2014 • Amirkabir University of Technology

1st All-girls Team / Regional ACM Contest • 2013 & 2014 • Sharif University of Technology

99.5 percentile / National University Entrance Exam • Fall 2013 • Iran

Product Designer | [Adanic](#) Banking Informatics

DEC 2016 - JUL 2018, Tehran

Award Winning Project: Designed a multi-signature corporate banking account solution (KeyLead) implemented and white-labeled in 10+ leading banks in Iran.

- Conducted stakeholder interviews and user research within the finance industry.
- Conducted iterative **contextual inquiries** and **usability testings** with users.
- Created experience and affinity maps to determine the user journeys.
- Provided annotated **high-fidelity interactive prototypes** to effectively communicate the design outcomes with the development team and clients.
- Provided an enhanced unified design for **iOS, android, and web applications** leading to the products being adopted by more than 10 major banks in Iran.

UX/UI Designer | [Torob](#) eCommerce Search Engine

JUN 2016 - SEP 2016, Tehran

- Conducted User Behaviour Analysis in different stages of the user journey.
- Conducted heuristic evaluations based on Baymard Institute's guidelines to identify potential pain points of the users.
- Leveraged UX research to the design of flows and interfaces of Torob's website, mobile applications, and their B2B eCommerce APIs.
- Created **low-fidelity prototypes, wireframes, and mockups** of the final product.
- Improved Torob's Alexa rank to be among the top 1000 in Iran.